



MIDWIFE

JOB DESCRIPTION

A midwife specializes in supporting and protecting the health of a mother-to-be and her baby during pregnancy, childbirth, and the baby's first weeks of life. They may also offer other health care services for women, such as exams and prescriptions counseling. In this role, you will advise and assist women and their families with the emotional and practical issues associated with pregnancy, labor, and newborn care.



SALARY

Newly qualified midwife ★★☆☆☆

Consultant midwife ★★★★★

INDUSTRY PROFILE

Many vacancies across the world • Demand for midwives growing as birth rates rise • Regulated profession with positions available in hospitals and in the community

AT A GLANCE



YOUR INTERESTS Women's health and welfare • Health and social service • Biology • Science • Mathematics • Social sciences • English



ENTRY QUALIFICATIONS Professional midwives must have degrees in nursing, midwifery, or both. Requirements vary based on the type of certification.



LIFESTYLE Due to the unpredictable nature of childbirth, midwives work in shifts. Community-based midwives must be on call in case of emergency.



LOCATION Midwives work in hospital wards, community health centers, or birthing units. Community-based midwives may visit parents at home.



THE REALITIES Pregnancy and labor can involve medical complications and emergencies, which can be emotionally stressful. Shift work can be tiring.

RELATED CAREERS

- ▶ **COUNSELOR** *see pp. 256–257*
- ▶ **HEALTH VISITOR** Visits patients in their homes to provide care following surgery, after childbirth, or for a range of other health issues.
- ▶ **NEONATAL NURSE** Provides nursing care for newborn babies who are premature or sick. Neonatal nurses work in special units in hospitals.
- ▶ **PEDIATRIC NURSE** Provides health care to children of all ages in hospitals, care homes, and schools. Pediatric nurses have to work closely with parents.
- ▶ **SONOGRAPHER** Uses ultrasound to examine unborn babies, checking their development and screening them for medical conditions.

There are more than 15,000 practicing midwives in the United States.